Capstone Project 1: Final Design Direction – AI-Powered Travel Planner

Final Chosen Design Direction:

Mood Board 1 – Minimalist & Elegant

Justification for Selection

After evaluating three distinct visual directions—Minimalist & Elegant, Bold & Adventurous, and Tech-Driven & Futuristic—the Minimalist & Elegant approach was selected for its strong alignment with both user needs and the product's core functional goals. This style prioritizes clarity, calm, and simplicity, which reflects our primary user persona (Anabel Jones), a busy professional who values organized, distraction-free interfaces.

Alignment with User Needs & UX Goals

The minimalist approach supports key UX goals in the following ways:

UX Goal	Minimalist Design Solution
Clarity & Simplicity	Clean layouts with soft tones guide users toward primary actions.
Ease of Navigation	Straightforward flows and clear hierarchy support smooth interaction.
Speed & Accessibility	Low-distraction UI enables quick task completion, ideal for mobile use.
Trust in AI	A polished, professional aesthetic instills confidence in automated suggestions.
Mobile Usability	Spacious layouts and intuitive tap zones improve experience on small screens.

Design Elements Summary

Design Element	Chosen Style
Color Palette	Muted pastels, whites, and soft neutrals for a calm look.
Typography	Sans-serif fonts like Inter and Lato for modern readability.
Layout	Card-based layout, clean grid structure, intuitive content blocks.
Imagery	High-quality destination images with ample white space.
Buttons & Interactions	Rounded edges, smooth transitions, minimalist CTAs.
Iconography	Monochrome line icons for clarity and simplicity.

Visual Cohesion & Interaction Flow

The **minimalist aesthetic** contributes to a natural **visual flow** by using hierarchy, white space, and consistent element spacing to guide users through onboarding, trip input, AI-generated results, and save/share functions.

- **Card-based sections** create rhythm and visual grouping.
- **Large headings and subtle dividers** improve orientation and task focus.
- **Whitespace** enhances clarity between actions, especially on mobile.

Brand Alignment & Competitive Differentiation

This design direction supports a **modern, premium brand identity**. Unlike cluttered or overly complex competitors, this planner stands out by offering:

- A **calm, intelligent assistant** aesthetic
- A design that reflects **confidence, balance, and usability**
- Clear differentiation through **restraint and clarity**, not overwhelming features

It positions the AI-powered travel planner as a tool users can **trust** for its intuitive simplicity and precision.

Transition to High-Fidelity Design

The Minimalist direction smoothly translates into a **scalable high-fidelity prototype**. It allows:

- Modular components like cards and toggles
- Micro-interactions (e.g., subtle button animations, smart transitions)
- Adaptive responsiveness across screen sizes using fluid grids and flexible typography

This will ensure **clean UI**, **seamless user experience**, and **technical feasibility** on both Android and iOS.

Conclusion

The **Minimalist & Elegant** design direction offers the perfect balance of **usability, trust, visual clarity, and brand personality**. It aligns with user behavior, supports the AI-driven vision of the product, and will be carried into the high-fidelity phase to deliver a cohesive and satisfying mobile experience.